

Timeline Compression Trap Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 25-35 min

Category	History	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	timeline-compression-trap

Big idea: The scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

Overview

Students build compressed timelines and see how scale choices make historical change appear sudden or gradual.

Student Prompt

Inspect Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: School example: policy change develops over two years, but a viral incident makes it look sudden. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Timeline Compression Trap Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — The scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Timeline Compression Trap Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How do historical representations shape interpretation?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how the scale of a timeline shapes historical interpretation.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Use an event sequence with both long-term causes and sudden triggers.
- Give groups different physical lengths of timeline paper.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- School example: policy change develops over two years, but a viral incident makes it look sudden.
- History example: reform movement builds slowly before one visible law or protest.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give groups the same set of event cards.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	One group uses a compressed timeline and another uses an expanded timeline.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students place events and write a one-sentence interpretation of the process.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups compare whether change looks sudden, gradual, inevitable, or contested.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how representation affects historical knowledge.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Your timeline is making an argument about pace and importance.
- What disappears when the scale changes?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use six event cards.
- Challenge: require students to mark continuity, change, and turning points separately.

Extension Tasks

- Students add a third timeline focused on one actor's perspective.
- Connect timeline scale to causation essays in history.

Related Activities

- Cause Web
- Same Event, Different Historian
- Graph Caption Framing